



## MORE TROUBLES

In December 1773, a group of colonists dressed as American Indians destroyed a shipment of British tea in an event known as the Boston Tea Party.

and dumped all the tea into the harbor. The British Parliament considered the incident, which became known as the Boston Tea Party, a deliberate act of defiance.

### BOILING POINT

Fifty-one women in Edenton, North Carolina, held a tea party of their own on October 25, 1774. Led by Penelope Barker, the protesters signed a declaration vowing they would not drink tea or use cloth imported from Great Britain. The group of protesters became known as the Edenton Tea Party. Barker said of the group: "Maybe it has only been men who have protested the king up to now. . . . That only means we women have taken too long to let our voices be heard. We are signing our names to a document, not hiding ourselves behind costumes like the men in Boston did at their tea party. The British will know who we are."<sup>1</sup>

King George was determined to punish Massachusetts, Boston in particular, for the Boston Tea Party. In March 1774, the British Parliament passed a series of laws known as the Coercive Acts to punish Massachusetts. One law suspended the Massachusetts government and banned town meetings. Another law closed Boston Harbor until colonists paid for the tea destroyed during the Boston Tea Party. The closure of the harbor hurt Boston's economy and eliminated many jobs.

The king replaced Massachusetts's governor with General Thomas Gage. Gage also served as the commander in chief of the British army in North America. One of Gage's first actions was to place Boston under martial law to crack down on rebellious protests.

The Coercive Acts only affected Massachusetts. King George had hoped this would isolate Massachusetts from the rest of the colonies. His plan backfired. The actions taken against Massachusetts only strengthened the other colonies' frustrations with the British Parliament. Representatives from the colonies formed a group called the Continental Congress. The delegates of the First Continental Congress met in Philadelphia in September 1774. Every colony except Georgia sent representatives to the Congress.

## **THE COLONIES TAKE ACTION**

The First Continental Congress passed a declaration of colonial rights, which upheld the colonies' right to govern themselves. The delegates also concluded that if British troops used force against any of the colonies, all the colonies should fight back as one. The Congress agreed to meet again in May 1775.

## GEORGIA'S ABSENCE

Georgia was the only colony not to send representatives to the First Continental Congress. Colonial leaders in Georgia were hoping Great Britain would send military troops to defend the colony from American Indians on its western frontier. They did not want to risk the British Parliament's anger. However, British aid never arrived. Georgia did not send delegates to the Second Continental Congress right away, but on July 8, 1775, Georgia decided to join the other colonies. Its delegates arrived in Philadelphia on July 20.

Shortly after the First Continental Congress ended, towns throughout the New England colonies started shoring up their defenses. Some civilians began stockpiling weapons and ammunition. These militiamen also began training in groups.

In March 1775, General Gage learned colonial militias had a substantial stash of weapons in Concord, Massachusetts, approximately 24 miles (39 km) west of Boston. Under orders from the British Parliament, Gage was preparing to confiscate the weapons being gathered in Concord. He was also determined to capture and imprison Hancock and Adams.

The citizens of Boston did not trust the British. They kept a close eye on the troops' every move. One patriot stumbled onto the British plan to go after the militias' weapons and tipped off the rest of the colonists. Boston silversmith Paul Revere and Doctor Joseph Warren, a leading Boston patriot, began watching the movement of British troops. On April 7, 1775, Revere and Warren gathered intelligence that Gage would be sending his men to raid Concord in approximately one week. Revere instructed the Concord militia to move its store of weapons. He also developed a series of signals to let the militias in towns on the way to Concord know when the British troops were heading their way and the path the troops were following.

## **THE BRITISH ARRIVE**

The British could have approached Concord from Boston by water, crossing the Charles River in boats, or by marching over land. If the British were coming by land, the patriots would hang a single lantern in Boston's Old North Church. If the British were coming by water, they would hang two lanterns. On the night of April 18, Gage ordered his troops to move out. They went by boat, and Revere's signal went out over the darkened countryside.

Revere and fellow patriot William Dawes mounted horses and rode out to warn colonists to be ready to battle the 700 armed redcoats heading toward Concord.<sup>2</sup> Most of the weapons had already been moved. However, Americans feared Gage's troops would capture Hancock and Adams. Both men were in Lexington, Massachusetts, approximately five miles (8 km) outside of Concord.

Revere and Dawes reached Lexington in plenty of time to warn of the impending British attack. Hancock and Adams escaped. Revere and Dawes met up with another rider, Samuel Prescott, and rode on to Concord. Meanwhile, militiamen in Lexington prepared for a fight. They hoped to stop, or at least slow, the British advance before the troops reached Concord.

As dawn broke on April 19, Gage's troops saw a line of 70 militiamen waiting for them in the middle of Lexington.<sup>3</sup> British commanders ordered the minutemen to leave. They refused. No one knows who fired the first shot, but chaos erupted as soon as it was fired. Eight militiamen were killed, and nine were wounded. After the skirmish, the British moved on. Only one redcoat had been slightly injured.

The British soon reached Concord, where approximately 250 militiamen were ready for a fight. But instead of attacking



When Revere spotted two lanterns in the Old North Church, he knew British soldiers would be traveling by water.

right away, the colonists fell back to the North Bridge, approximately one mile (1.6 km) outside of town. The redcoats split up, sending regiments throughout Concord to search

buildings for weapons. This gave the Concord militia time to wait for reinforcements from neighboring towns.

It did not take long for the ranks of militiamen to swell to approximately 500. The militia began marching over the North Bridge toward town, where they encountered several British regiments. Shots rang out, and men fell on both sides. Gage's men were more interested in searching for weapons than fighting the militias. The British pulled back, and the militiamen hurried into defensive positions.

The British found few weapons in Concord and began returning to Boston, but the fighting was not over. More militiamen had arrived throughout the day. Between 3,000 and 4,000 militiamen hid in the woods along the road.<sup>4</sup> They shot at the returning British troops from the cover of brush and the tops of trees. The redcoats were not prepared for such an attack. If British reinforcements had not arrived from Boston, all the British troops that had gone to Concord that day would have been killed or taken prisoner. The American Revolution had begun.

Colonists fought the British troops at the North Bridge  
outside of Concord.



